

THE PRICE OF YEARS

A Prequel to The Drift — E. R. Stahl

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From the Registers of the Exchequer, first book — the page the Censor ordered never to be rewritten.

“In that year the count came out even. It came out even because a man made it come out even. Of him the Exchequer keeps no name: only the shortfall he settled out of his own pocket. They called it the First Dissent. It was also the last time a debt could be paid with one’s own life.”

1

The register weighed more at the end of the day.

Korr knew only one thing about it, and he knew it with his hands: the paper didn't change. The arm did. In the morning he lifted the volume from the lectern without thinking. In the evening he let it fall the last finger's width onto the wood.

He had closed five names. Nine were left.

He always counted them twice. Not out of duty — duty he had used up in the third year. He counted them because a number said once is a rumor, and a rumor can be wrong. Said twice, it is a fact. Korr wrote facts.

The Exchequer's lamp gave no warmth. It was a rule, not a fault: in the halls where the lists of the living were kept, nothing that gave heat was burned, because heat consumes, and the Exchequer did not consume. The Exchequer distributed. Korr blew on his fingers out of habit. The breath made no difference.

The Collector came in without knocking.

Knocking was for doors that could be closed. Korr did not lift his eyes from the line. He heard the step stop at the right distance — three tiles, always three, the Collector measured even the floor — and a hand set a folded sheet on the lectern, beside the volume.

“From the Censor,” the Collector said. “For tonight.”

Korr finished the line. Period. Blotted it.

“There’s nothing else for tonight,” he said. “Nine names, and I have them.”

“This is the tenth.”

Korr set down the pen. He set it down right, parallel to the margin, because a crooked pen on the register was the one thing that still tightened something in his stomach. Then he opened the sheet.

One line. One subtraction. The Exchequer did not explain. The Exchequer took.

Korr, Liv. Years to subtract: eleven.

He read the number before the name. Eleven. He read it clean, the way he read everything, and for a moment it was only a number, and numbers Korr knew how to hold at arm’s length, like the volume, like the cold lamp, like the five already closed.

Then he read the name.

And the arm, all at once, no longer held the weight.

2

The Collector had not gone.

Korr knew it without looking. Three tiles. The breath that couldn't be heard. The Exchequer chose men who made no noise, because noise is a request, and you ask a Collector for nothing.

"There's a mistake," Korr said.

"The Exchequer doesn't write mistakes."

"Liv is eleven." Korr heard his own voice come out flat, off the line, and it was the one thing that kept him standing. "You're subtracting eleven years. You're subtracting everything she's had. What's left is a name with no margin."

"What's left is the count, even."

Korr lowered his eyes to the sheet again. Eleven. The figure had not moved. Figures did not move: that was what made them bearable, usually. A subtraction hates no one.

"Who put her on the list," he said. It was not a question. Questions the Collector did not carry back.

"The Censor keeps the living," the Collector said. "You write them. I collect them. None of us chooses." A pause, exactly the length of a man who has said this a thousand times. "You least of all, Korr. You only write."

You only write.

Korr had built three years on that sentence. He had slept on it. Fourteen names that evening, and for each one the same wall: I don't call them, I don't collect them, I only keep the line straight. The pen parallel to the margin. The hands at arm's length from the weight.

It still held, the sentence. He felt it hold even now, with Liv's name on the lectern. It held for all of them.

Except one.

"Tonight," the Collector said. "The count closes at the spent bell. After that, the line belongs to the Censor." He turned. The three tiles, back again. At the door he stopped, and not out of courtesy — the Exchequer had no courtesies — but to hand over one last thing, the way a tool is handed over. "The register doesn't look at names, Scribe. It looks at the sum. That's the only thing they taught it to see."

The door closed without a sound.

Korr was left alone with the open volume and the lamp that gave no warmth.

He read the sheet again. Then he read the Collector's last sentence again, which was not on the sheet, which was already elsewhere, but which went on sitting there as if someone had written it in the margin.

The register looks at the sum.

Korr knew the register better than the Collector. Better than the Censor, perhaps, because the Censor owned it and he *kept* it, and those are two different things, like owning a lamp and knowing how cold it stays. He knew what the register saw. He knew, above all, what the register did *not* see.

It did not see which line the years came from.

It saw only that, in the end, they were missing.

Korr laid his open palm on the page of the living. The paper was neither cold nor warm. It was paper. Somewhere beneath that palm was a line that read *Korr, Liv, eleven*, and somewhere else — three fingers higher, in the section that kept the names of those who wrote, because the Exchequer wrote its scribes too — was a line that read *Korr*, and nothing more, and a number beside it he had never counted twice. He had never wanted to know it.

Now he wanted to know it.

He counted it. Once. Then, because a number said once is a rumor, he counted it again.

The two counts came out even.

And for the first time in three years, keeping the line straight, Korr understood that he was no longer only writing.

3

Outside, the sky could be counted.

It was the way people said *it's cold* without saying it. You went out, you lifted your head, you counted the stars. Whoever counted fewer than the night before went back in and said nothing. Korr had stopped counting them the year he learned to read the register: inside the Exchequer the number of the living was more exact than the number of the sky, and more honest, because at least it didn't pretend to stay the same.

Tonight he counted them. He reached seventy and stopped, not because they ran out, but because seventy was enough to know.

His house was eleven doors from the Exchequer. He had always known that. Tonight the number stayed on him the whole way, like a hand on the back of the neck.

Liv was keeping it lit.

He found her the way he did every evening: kneeling at the low brazier, her back straight, a sliver of peat in her hand, watching that the embers didn't drop below red. *Keeping it lit* did not warm the room — nothing warmed a room anymore, not really — but it was a task, and a task holds a child still better than fire does. He had taught it to her. You keep it lit. Not for the warmth. Because as long as

you keep it lit, you have something to count in the morning.

“Fourteen,” she said, without turning. She knew his step. “Fourteen tonight?”

“Fourteen.”

“A lot.”

“A lot.”

Korr set down the volume — there was no volume; he set it down anyway, the arm made the evening’s gesture — and sat behind her, on the edge of the pallet. The back of Liv’s neck took the brazier’s light. Eleven years. Korr had seen them all. He had counted them without noticing, evening after evening, the way you count stars: the first word, the first step, the first time she had asked why the Exchequer’s lamp gave no warmth and he hadn’t known what to answer that wasn’t true.

She had eleven years. A full number.

Somewhere, on a line, the same number was now waiting to be taken.

“Did you count the sky?” she asked.

“Seventy.”

Liv turned. She had the way children have of taking a number and weighing it at once, without shame. “Last night you counted more.”

“Yes.”

“Then some are missing.”

“Some are always missing,” Korr said. “That’s how you know.”

She went back to the brazier. Satisfied. For Liv a count that came out even was a closed count, and a closed count was a good thing: he had taught her that too, without

knowing he was teaching it.

Korr watched the embers kept alive by an eleven-year-old hand, and counted one last time. Not the stars. Not the names. Himself.

His own line he knew by heart now: *Korr*, and beside it a number he had counted twice inside the Exchequer and that out here, by the brazier, he counted a third time, because three times a number is no longer a fact. It's a decision.

The years he had. The years it would take.

They came out even.

Enough to cover eleven. Enough, with a margin so thin that afterward all that would be left of Korr on the register was the name, no number beside it — the same line he closed fourteen times an evening, the line of a man with no margin left.

Liv added the sliver of peat. The embers rose back to red.

“Will it stay lit?” Korr asked.

Liv looked at him the way you look at someone who has asked an obvious thing.

“I’ve got it,” she said.

4

At the spent bell the Exchequer had no guards.

It needed none. The living were written, and what is written does not run. Korr opened it with his own key — every Scribe had one, because the register had to be kept, and keeping is work that knows no hours — and went into the hall where the lamp gave no warmth.

It had stayed lit. The Exchequer's lamps stayed lit always. It was the one thing, in the whole city, that did not let itself be counted at the end of the day, because it never fell.

The volume was where he had left it. The folded sheet beside it. *Korr, Liv. Years to subtract: eleven.*

Korr did not read it again. He knew it. He knew it the way you know your own step.

He sat. He took the pen. He set it parallel to the margin, once more, because the hand wanted to make the right gestures to the last, and he let it.

Then he opened the register to the section of the living.

He found Liv's line. *Korr, Liv, eleven.* Eleven years she had, eleven to take: the subtraction the Exchequer asked for left zero, and zero, on the register of the living, is not a number. It is a line that closes.

Korr did not close it.

He went up three fingers. To the section of those who wrote, because the Exchequer wrote its scribes too, and because a debt, to come out even, has to find another line to come down from.

He found his own.

And here the hand stopped. Not from fear — fear was a warmth, and inside the Exchequer there were no warmths. It stopped because for three years that hand had kept a single line straight, *I only write, I don't choose*, and now it was about to write the thing that line had never allowed for: a name that chooses to come down in another's place.

The Collector's sentence came back, exact. *The register looks at the sum. It doesn't look at which line the years come from.*

Korr set the pen down.

He took eleven off his own line. He added them to Liv's. He did not write why: the register had no column for why. He wrote only the numbers, clean, the way he had written everything. Liv went back up to eleven. Korr came down to what was left — little, the margin of a line that closes soon — and beside his own name, for the first time, he did not count twice. He had no need. He knew.

He blotted it.

The sum, at the foot of the page, was identical to before. Eleven taken from one side, eleven from the other: the count came out even. It came out perfect. The Censor, in the morning, would find the figure he expected, and the figure would not tell him where it came from, because the figure had never been taught to see that. He would see a subtraction carried out. A line closed. The order obeyed.

No one would count the two lines apart. No one counts the lines when the sum comes out even. It is the first thing one stops doing, before a count that's even: one stops looking at *how*.

Korr closed the volume. It weighed the way it did at the end of the day, though the day was not yet here.

He stayed a moment with his palm on the cover. Then he stood, and the act cost him more than it should have, and he knew — without saying it to himself, because there were no words at the Exchequer to say it — that it was not the night's weariness. It was the margin. He had spent it. Now he walked as a man with no number beside his name.

He put out his own lamp — his own, the one he carried home, not the Exchequer's, which never went out.

Outside, the sky could still be counted.

Korr did not count it. He had already made one count come out even that night. That was enough for him.

He went home, eleven doors, and at each door he thought one thing, and he thought it flat, off the line, because it was the only way he knew to hold true things up:

She's got it now.

5

They called him back before the first bell.

Korr knew it before the Collector's step even reached his door: a count that's even is not questioned, but a count that comes out even *too* well is looked at. It was the one thing that could give him away. Not the shortfall. The perfection.

The Exchequer, by day, was full of scribes and empty of voices. They crossed it in silence to the high hall, where the master register lay open on a lectern no Scribe touched. There the lamp was larger, and colder.

The Censor was not there. The Censor was never there. There was his voice, which reached the Exchequer the way the cold reached it: without anyone knowing from where, and without letting itself be warmed.

"The sum comes out even," the voice said.

"It does," Korr said.

"And one line is wrong."

Korr did not answer. There was nothing to correct. The line was not wrong: it was *paid*. But at the Exchequer those two words were the same thing, and he understood, in that silence, that the difference was known only to him.

The Collector opened the master register to the page of the living. He found Liv's line — eleven, untouched. He

went up three fingers, to the line of the scribes, and stopped.

“Korr,” he read. “No number.”

“No number,” Korr said.

“Where the eleven years came down from.”

“From my line.”

For the first time the Censor’s voice was silent a long while. Korr had closed fourteen names an evening for three years and had never heard the Exchequer stop like this. The Exchequer did not stop: the Exchequer distributed. Now it stood before a thing that had no column.

“It can be done,” the voice said at last. It was not a question. It was a deathless man discovering, late, an edge of his own power.

“It can be done,” Korr said. “The register looks at the sum. It doesn’t look at which line the debt comes down from. You taught it not to look.”

The silence again. Longer.

When the voice came back, it had changed. No longer cold: *attentive*. And it is the attentiveness of the Perennials that frightens most, because a deathless man who sets himself to listen has all the time there is to close what he has heard.

“Strike the line,” the Censor said. “Both of them. Leave the sum.”

The Collector took up the pen.

“The Scribe’s name comes off the register,” the voice went on. “Off the living and off the scribes. He is not dead: he is *struck*. One who is struck has done nothing, because he is not there. And what he did was never something that could be done.” A pause, exactly the length of a law being

born. “From tonight a debt is settled only where the Exchequer sends it. Never backward. Never from one’s own line. Whoever tries will not be punished: he will be struck, like this one. Take even his mistake from him. Leave only that the count, at the foot, comes out even.”

The Collector wrote. Or rather: he took away. He drew a line through Korr’s name in the scribes. He drew a line through the eleven that had come down. At the foot of the page the sum stayed identical, perfect, clean — the figure the Censor expected, which did not say where it came from, which would never again say where any year came from, because it had just become forbidden to ask.

Korr watched his own name vanish under a line of ink and felt nothing the Exchequer had a name for.

He still had his name outside, eleven doors away, in the mouth of a child who kept it lit. That they could not take. It was written nowhere. It was the one thing, in the whole city, surer than the register.

“You may go,” the voice said. “There is no one to go.”

Korr went.

6

Korr came home by day. It had never happened before.

For three years he had known those eleven doors only at the spent bell, in the dark, with the volume heavy. By day the street was a different one. Shorter. People still lifted their heads to the sky, out of habit, even though by day the stars can't be counted: you looked up all the same, because to stop looking was to stop hoping that the count, tonight, would come out the same.

Korr did not look up. He had already made one count come out even.

Liv was at the brazier. By day the embers showed less — the light from outside put them out to the eye even when it didn't put them out for real — but she kept them all the same, kneeling, her back straight, the sliver of peat in her hand. Keeping it lit was not for the warmth. Korr knew that better than anyone now.

"You didn't go out tonight," she said. She did not turn. She knew his step even by day.

"I went out," Korr said. "I came back."

"How many tonight?"

Korr stopped on the threshold.

Fourteen, he should have said. Fourteen names closed, like every evening. And that night he had closed the

fourteen, truly. But there had been a fifteenth, and that one he had not closed: he had opened it. He had taken a line that was going to zero and sent it back to eleven, and paid the difference from his own, and now of his number nothing was left, nowhere, except the thin margin a man carries who has spent everything and walks still.

“One,” he said. “One tonight.”

Liv thought about it. She weighed the number, the way she weighed all numbers, without shame.

“Few,” she said.

“Few.”

“Then it was a good night.”

Korr watched her keep the embers. Eleven years. He had counted them all, and now he had given them too: the same eleven, twice, once in the blood and once in the register, and of all the things he had written in three years that was the one the register would not remember. They had struck it. *What he did was never something that could be done.*

He sat behind her, on the edge of the pallet, like the evening before. The back of Liv’s neck took the brazier’s light even by day. He no longer had a number beside his name. She did. It was enough.

“Will you teach me to count the sky?” Liv asked. “The real one. Not the doors. The stars.”

Korr had stopped years ago. Inside the Exchequer the count of the living was more exact, and more honest. But the Exchequer had just struck his name from the living, and his most exact count now was this straight back before a brazier.

“I’ll teach you,” he said. “But the sky loses some every night. You know that.”

“I know,” Liv said. “That’s why you count it. To know how many are left.”

She added the peat. The embers rose back to red.

And Korr — who had kept a line straight for three years telling himself *I only write, I don’t choose* — knew that the sentence had died that night, on the register, under a line of ink, and that from that struck lie everything would be born: the Houses, the lists, the debt that binds men closer than blood, and one day, far off, a woman who counts worlds and believes she is only counting.

No one would know it. It was forbidden to know it.

But the embers stayed lit.

And someone, somewhere, was keeping them.

The End.

KEEP READING

*The lie Korr wrote into the register is settled, five
centuries later, in*

THE DRIFT — Book One: Half a Degree

by E. R. Stahl.

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